

Primary Source Reading 1: Mill's *Utilitarianism*, Chapter I — General Remarks

Philosophy Honors: Ethics / Lesson 2.02 — Does the End Justify the Means? By John Stuart Mill (1863)

Before you read: Mill opens not by stating his own theory but by diagnosing a problem: after more than two thousand years of moral philosophy, thinkers still cannot agree on the single standard by which right and wrong are to be judged. As you read, notice the two rival schools he identifies, and watch closely how he uses Kant as his example of where the rival approach goes wrong. This chapter is Mill clearing the ground before he builds his own case in Chapter II.

An Unresolved Controversy

There are few circumstances among those which make up the present condition of human knowledge, more unlike what might have been expected, or more significant of the backward state in which speculation on the most important subjects still lingers, than the little progress which has been made in the decision of the controversy respecting the criterion of right and wrong. From the dawn of philosophy, the question concerning the summum bonum, or, what is the same thing, concerning the foundation of morality, has been accounted the main problem in speculative thought, has occupied the most gifted intellects, and divided them into sects and schools, carrying on a vigorous warfare against one another. And after more than two thousand years the same discussions continue, philosophers are still ranged under the same contending banners, nor is there yet appearance of a consentient unanimity.

Two Schools, One Shared Problem

There is a strong tendency in most speculative inquiries to a division into two schools, one which considers the moral faculty to be a branch of our reason, the other of our sensations. According to the one opinion, the principles of morals are evident a priori, requiring nothing to command assent, except that the meaning of the terms be understood. According to the other doctrine, right and wrong, as well as truth and falsehood, are questions of observation and experience. But both hold equally that morality must be deduced from principles; and the intuitive school affirm as strongly as the inductive, that there is a science of morals. Yet they seldom attempt to make out a list of the a priori principles which are to serve as the premises of the science; still more rarely do they make any effort to reduce those various principles to one first principle, or common ground of obligation... Yet to support their pretensions there ought either to be some one fundamental principle or law, at the root of all morality, or if there be several, there should be a determinate order of precedence

among them; and the one principle, or the rule for deciding between the various principles when they conflict, ought to be self-evident.

Even Utility's Critics Depend on It

Although the non-existence of an acknowledged first principle has made ethics not so much a guide as a consecration of men's actual sentiments, still, as men's sentiments, both of favour and of aversion, are greatly influenced by what they suppose to be the effects of things upon their happiness, the principle of utility, or as Bentham latterly called it, the greatest happiness principle, has had a large share in forming the moral doctrines even of those who most scornfully reject its authority. Nor is there any school of thought which refuses to admit that the influence of actions on happiness is a most material and even predominant consideration in many of the details of morals, however unwilling to acknowledge it as the fundamental principle of morality, and the source of moral obligation. I might go much further, and say that to all those a priori moralists who deem it necessary to argue at all, utilitarian arguments are indispensable.

Mill's Example: Where Kant's Alternative Fails

I cannot help referring, for illustration, to a systematic treatise by one of the most illustrious of them, the *Metaphysics of Ethics*, by Kant. This remarkable man, whose system of thought will long remain one of the landmarks in the history of philosophical speculation, does, in the treatise in question, lay down a universal first principle as the origin and ground of moral obligation; it is this: "So act, that the rule on which thou actest would admit of being adopted as a law by all rational beings." But when he begins to deduce from this precept any of the actual duties of morality, he fails, almost grotesquely, to show that there would be any contradiction, any logical (not to say physical) impossibility, in the adoption by all rational beings of the most outrageously immoral rules of conduct. All he shows is that the consequences of their universal adoption would be such as no one would choose to incur.

What Kind of Proof Is Possible for an Ultimate End?

On the present occasion, I shall, without further discussion of the other theories, attempt to contribute something towards the understanding and appreciation of the Utilitarian or Happiness theory, and towards such proof as it is susceptible of. It is evident that this cannot be proof in the ordinary and popular meaning of the term. Questions of ultimate ends are not amenable to direct proof. Whatever can be proved to be good, must be so by being shown to be a means to something admitted to be good without proof. The medical art is proved to be good by its conducing to health; but how is it possible to prove that health is good? The art of music is good, for the reason, among others, that it produces pleasure; but what proof is it possible to give that pleasure is good? If, then, it is asserted that there is a comprehensive formula, including all things which are in themselves good, and that whatever else is good, is not so as an end, but as a mean, the formula may be accepted or rejected, but is not a subject of what is commonly understood by proof. We are not, however, to infer that its acceptance or rejection must depend on blind impulse, or arbitrary choice. There

is a larger meaning of the word proof, in which this question is as amenable to it as any other of the disputed questions of philosophy.

After you read: Notice what Mill is and is not claiming about proof. He concedes upfront that no ultimate end — not happiness, not anything else — can be proved the way a geometric theorem is proved, because proof of that kind always works by showing something is a means to some further good, and an ultimate end is by definition not a means to anything further. This matters for how you read the rest of the *Utilitarianism*: Mill is not going to offer you a deductive argument with airtight premises. He is going to offer considerations that, added up, are meant to make withholding assent to the utilitarian standard unreasonable. As you move to Chapter II, keep an eye on whether his “larger meaning of proof” actually delivers what he promises here — and notice, too, how he uses Kant specifically to make his case that rival first principles fare no better.